Reflective Analysis of Decision-Making and Problem-Solving

Important Decision: Moving from Italy to Brunei

My original approach:

One important decision I've made was to relocate with my family from Italy to Brunei when my husband received a job offer. Our daughters were two and four years old. I worked as a music teacher, and my husband had been made redundant. We were struggling financially and uncertain about our future. This was starting to take its toll on our marriage. The opportunity offered financial stability and a clean slate. We had only a few weeks to decide.

My husband and I made a list of pros and cons. The pros were the significantly higher salary, benefits package, improved standard of living, and the chance for our daughters to grow up in a safe country with a tropical climate and outdoor-centric culture. We also knew that our children would attend a smaller school and that we could travel to visit other countries in South-East Asia. We could begin reconstructing our family life away from the pressures we experienced in Italy. The cons were more personal. Neither of us had visited Brunei. My husband had never lived outside Italy, and we both had no prior experience of living in Asia. We would be moving further from family in the UK and Italy. I would need to resign from my job without knowing whether I would be allowed to work in Brunei. I faced the possibility of becoming financially reliant on my husband and losing a sense of who I was professionally.

We talked it through with our families. Mine was supportive, and my husband's focused on how far away we would be and how uncertain everything was. We tried not to let their anxiety overwhelm our needs as a family of four. We concluded that the salary, opportunity for family, and chance of a slower-paced life were more important than the cons. My husband accepted the job, I resigned from my teaching position, and we began preparing for the move.

A module-informed approach:

If I could revisit my decision-making process, I'd employ Halpern and Dunn's (2023) four-part model, approaching the situation critically, choosing relevant skills, using them effectively, and observing my reasoning. I would word my question more thoughtfully: "Which alternative best safeguards our finances, our daughters' wellbeing, our marriage and each adult's long-term autonomy?" (Halpern & Dunn, 2023). In doing so, I would not allow the decision to devolve into simply taking or turning down one seemingly great offer. Spacing out judgements would allow me to think of alternatives. Alternatives might involve remaining in Italy until my husband secured a job, migrating together instantly, him undertaking an initial exploratory trip, arranging a deferred family relocation with his employer, or a temporary one-year move necessitating a formal review. I would develop a weighted decision matrix based on subjective value. Categories might include estimated income minus realistic expenses, contract certainty, quality of schooling and healthcare, comfort of housing, ability to communicate with family left behind, my career prospects, impacts on the marriage, and ease of returning to Europe. Each category would be ranked for importance, and each rating would be supported by evidence.

I would distinguish facts from predictions. Salary and benefits were facts and could be verified against the contract. Optimistic assumptions that Brunei would offer us a better lifestyle or repair our marriage needed examination. According to Lerner et al. (2015), emotions may affect people's judgements of risks and values. Fear of unemployment and hope for a fresh start may therefore have made the offer seem more appealing than the facts warranted. Prospect theory indicates that decisions are framed around reference points and that potential losses can be overweighted (Kahneman & Tversky, 1979). I may have considered staying in Italy only as continued loss of income. I apparently discounted losses associated with moving there, such as my salary and career network.

To challenge myside bias, each of us would construct the strongest case against our preferred option rather than collect only supporting information. Stanovich and West (2008) show that intelligence alone does not reliably prevent one-sided reasoning. I would therefore seek evidence from current and former expatriate families, teachers' spouses and employees whose contracts had ended unexpectedly.

Finally, I would conduct a premortem following Klein (2008). We would imagine the move had failed after one year and list possible causes: I was isolated, the children struggled, the marriage remained tense, the contract ended, or family separation became intolerable. Each risk would have a safeguard, such as emergency savings, planned visits, an investigation of my work rights, and agreed circumstances that would trigger our return. Klein's premortem technique is designed to make concerns and hidden weaknesses easier to express during planning.

The informed process might still have led us to Brunei. By recording the reasons for each score, we could later determine whether the decision had been sound even if an unpredictable outcome eventually occurred. This distinction is important retrospectively. However, it would have produced a decision based on weighted evidence, alternatives and contingency planning rather than urgency and hope. The original approach identified obvious advantages and disadvantages, but the revised process would have better protected my independence and allowed the decision to be reviewed. It would also have made the trade-offs explicit, particularly the unequal professional consequences for my husband and me, rather than treating the family as though every member carried the same risks.

Significant Problem: Managing an Expanded Music-Teaching Role

My original approach:

A significant problem arose when my music-teaching role suddenly expanded. I had taught Early Years and Key Stage 1 through singing, movement, rhythm games and percussion. I was then informed that I would also teach Key Stage 2 and Years 7, 8 and 9 from the following term. No complete schemes of work were supplied, yet the older pupils required increasingly advanced work in notation, instrumental performance, composition, keyboard skills, songwriting, listening and music technology.

My first response was to plan every lesson separately. I spent evenings searching online, downloading worksheets and creating presentations. This became unmanageable because I collected more material than I could use and repeatedly planned similar concepts from the beginning.

I listed every class and its available lessons. I grouped them into Early Years, Key Stage 1, Key Stage 2 and Middle Years, and identified the key skills required at each stage. Rather than writing individual lessons immediately, I produced half-term overviews containing a topic, learning outcomes, activities and a final outcome. I reused concepts at different levels: rhythm involved movement for younger children, percussion patterns for Key Stage 2 and composition for older students.

I created a lesson plan template, planned topics in batches, and organised reusable resources into digital folders. In the first lessons, I assessed pupils' knowledge and adjusted subsequent work. I also asked colleagues for previous materials and recorded brief evaluations after each lesson. These changes created a manageable routine, although I reached this solution only after considerable overload.

A module-informed approach:

Reapproaching the problem, I would define it before producing lessons. Halpern and Dunn (2023) distinguish loosely specified from clearly represented problems. I would convert "plan music for almost the entire school" into: "Create a progressive one-term curriculum for each stage, within two protected planning periods weekly, using the equipment and teaching time available."

Simon and Newell's (1971) problem-space account would help represent the starting state, goal, constraints and possible actions. I would construct a curriculum matrix with year groups as rows and rhythm, notation, performance, composition, listening and technology as columns. I would mark existing resources, required outcomes and gaps. This would show where one resource could be differentiated and where genuinely new planning was needed. Their account describes problem-solving in terms of problem spaces and processes that adapt the thinker's limited information-processing system to the task.

I would use the sequential stages described by D'Zurilla and Goldfried (1971): define the problem, generate alternatives, evaluate them, select a response and verify whether it works. Alternatives would include adapting a published scheme, shared planning, requesting management support, using common topics with differentiated outcomes, and limiting new units during the first term. I would compare these choices according to preparation time, curriculum coverage, student engagement, adaptability and future usefulness. D'Zurilla and Goldfried's model presents problem-solving as a deliberate, staged process rather than an immediate response to pressure.

Next, I would divide the task into subgoals: audit requirements, assess prior learning, map progression, choose one unit per year group, prepare common resources, teach, review and revise. I would work backwards from an observable outcome. If Year 9 were expected to produce a recorded group song, earlier lessons would cover structure, chords, lyrics, arrangement, rehearsal and recording.

Sweller's (1988) cognitive-load research would change how I managed the workload. Attempting to hold every year group, resource and sequence in mind created unnecessary mental demand. The curriculum matrix, standard template, batching and central resource bank would externalise information and reduce duplication. I would also set a fixed stopping point so additional searching could not consume unlimited time. Sweller argues that conventional problem-solving can consume substantial processing capacity, leaving fewer cognitive resources available for learning and acquiring organised schemas.

Early lessons would test my assumptions. If pupils could read a basic rhythm, they should perform it accurately; if not, I would adapt the next lesson. Short performances, questioning and exit tasks would provide evidence. Hill-Briggs (2003) also emphasises that real-world problem-solving involves cognitive, educational and social-contextual factors. I would therefore treat workload as an organisational issue requiring protected planning time, resources and communication with management, rather than assuming I alone had to absorb the expansion.

My original and informed solutions share practical features, including grouping classes, assessing pupils and reusing materials. The difference is timing and structure. Originally, I discovered these methods through exhaustion. The module-informed approach would introduce clear representation, alternatives, subgoals, workload limits and evaluation from the beginning. It would probably have produced a stronger curriculum more quickly while reducing stress and protecting teaching quality. It could also have provided clearer evidence when requesting additional time or support from management.

References

D'Zurilla, T. J., & Goldfried, M. R. (1971). Problem solving and behavior modification. *Journal of Abnormal Psychology, 78*(1), 107–126. https://doi.org/10.1037/h0031360

Halpern, D. F., & Dunn, D. S. (2023). *Thought and knowledge: An introduction to critical thinking* (6th ed.). Routledge. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781003025412

Hill-Briggs, F. (2003). Problem solving in diabetes self-management: A model of chronic illness self-management behavior. *Annals of Behavioral Medicine, 25*(3), 182–193. https://doi.org/10.1207/S15324796ABM2503_04

Kahneman, D., & Tversky, A. (1979). Prospect theory: An analysis of decision under risk. *Econometrica, 47*(2), 263–291. https://doi.org/10.2307/1914185

Klein, G. (2008). Performing a project premortem. *IEEE Engineering Management Review, 36*(2), 103–104. https://doi.org/10.1109/EMR.2008.4534313

Lerner, J. S., Li, Y., Valdesolo, P., & Kassam, K. S. (2015). Emotion and decision making. *Annual Review of Psychology, 66*, 799–823. https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-psych-010213-115043

Simon, H. A., & Newell, A. (1971). Human problem solving: The state of the theory in 1970. *American Psychologist, 26*(2), 145–159. https://doi.org/10.1037/h0030806

Stanovich, K. E., & West, R. F. (2008). On the failure of cognitive ability to predict myside and one-sided thinking biases. *Thinking & Reasoning, 14*(2), 129–167. https://doi.org/10.1080/13546780701679764

Sweller, J. (1988). Cognitive load during problem solving: Effects on learning. *Cognitive Science, 12*(2), 257–285. https://doi.org/10.1207/s15516709cog1202_4